

Introduction to FastTrack to Office Suites

Many of you have grown up using pre-installed (ahem...pirated) versions of Microsoft Office but in today's market the options are many - from expensive offline office suites to open source cloud based freeware. But with the so many options, be it offline, online, proprietary, open source etc. it can get confusing to know what's right for you. And as a greater quantity of work shifts to the online realm, with cloud collaboration between classmates and colleagues, it's imperative that you work on an application platform that is stable, flexible and powerful, not to mention affordable. That's where this issue of FastTrack comes in - where we lay bare the broad range of options before you in terms that make sense.

But before we begin let's address the elephant in the room. You may think - "FastTrack to Office Suites!? Really?" - but before you pull the trigger on your sardonic gun consider this - most of the work you've ever done or will ever do in your career will be dependent on computer applications like Microsoft Office or Google Drive. Wouldn't life be simpler if you just figured them all out now, once and for all? And that's exactly what this issue of FastTrack is all about. To demystify the mundane and perhaps even make it interesting to some of you.

We begin by simply explaining what an office suite actually is, and what you should expect to encounter when using them. The various applications that constitute an office suite vary but all have a common set. We introduce each of their components and help you make sense of their offline and online utilities with respect to your needs.

We next step into the detailed workings of the common applications found in most office suites such as word processing programs, spreadsheet